

Young commander

Nguyen Van Thieu was born in November 1924, but would later change his birthday to April 5, on the advice of an astrologer. The son of a fisherman, he grew up in the poor, coastal province of Ninh Thuan, and chose to join the Viet Minh in the struggle against the French. Despite rising in its ranks, after a year he renounced the brutal communist front and chose instead to ally with the French—even attending infantry school in Coëtquidan, France.

Thieu fought well against the Viet Minh. He drove them from his village in 1954, even attacking those hiding in his family home, and from there his military career picked up momentum. After the First Indochina War ended, Thieu joined the new South Vietnamese Army (ARVN) and underwent military training in the US in 1957 and 1960. In 1960, commanding the Seventh Division, Thieu sent troops to defend President Diem from a coup attempt, but later turned on him; he led an attack on the presidential palace during the coup that ousted Diem in 1963.

Thieu's political and military ascent continued. Appointed a general, he became a member of a group of young officers known as the young Turks. In 1964, they helped to oust the ruling military junta, and the group also played a role in a subsequent coup in 1965. That year, Thieu became chief of state under the new government of fellow young Turk Nguyen Cao Ky.

President and general

Thieu had taken a back seat to Ky in 1965, but this all changed in the 1967 election. With ARVN support, Thieu displaced Ky to run as the presidential candidate, making Ky his running mate. The ticket won with nearly 35 percent of the vote. Thieu promised to preside over a democratic government, enact social reforms, and crack down on corruption. However, he also increased mobilization, swiftly removed rivals, and engaged in censorship—his authoritarian style causing some to call him a dictator.

When peace talks began in 1968, Thieu did not attend, refusing to acknowledge the communist National Liberation Front (NLF) as a legitimate authority. He hesitantly accepted Nixon's Vietnamization policy in 1969, but warned that he would only support it if the US continued to supply funds and equipment to the ARVN.

As the war continued, concern from the West about Thieu's regime grew, especially after the 1971 election, which appeared to have been rigged in his favor. As the US became more determined to reach a peace agreement, Thieu became a major obstacle, angered by the secret talks between Hanoi and Washington.